

Ancient China

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This post forms part of my [‘aspects of the novel’](#) collection. Please do note that these entries, which may appear basic, are simply my own notes on the subject. They implicitly or explicitly describe a canon not of my own making or choosing and replicate this from various sources. The original encyclopaedia articles are far more comprehensive, nuanced and worth consulting. I am especially conscious, in this article, of the danger of causing offense by grossly simplifying a national history.

Fiction, in China, was held in low esteem for a very long time. The very term for fiction ‘xiao shuo’ literally means ‘small talk’. The novel was a particular latecomer to China and did not appear until the Mongol Yuan Dynasty (1279-1368).

The first Chinese novel is the *Sanguo yanyi* (1522) or *The Romance of the Three Kingdoms*, often attributed to Luo Guanzhong. This text covers a century of history of early Imperial China. Another early novel is the *Shuihu zhuan* (1614), translated as *Water Margin*. This novel charts the course of a set of philanthropic robbers in the Northern Song Dynasty (960-1126). Early Chinese novels, according to Yang, p. 19, did not have anything like Homer's *Iliad* and *Odyssey* to act as intertextual reference points for their work.

As might be indicated by the subject of *Sanguo yanyi*, history and fiction are blurred categories in Ancient Chinese literature. History and fiction are all included under a word that might be translated as “pattern”. Hence, much early Chinese writing is historical, with a narrative nature. For

instance the *Shu jing* (Book of Documents) is a record of historical political speeches. The *Zuo zhuan* is the earliest narrative history.

One of the most important ancient Chinese histories, but regarded as a work of literature, is Sima Qian's *Shi ji* or *Historical Records*. Significantly, this work focuses on people, rather than just charting historical events, hence lending it the literary quality. This work could be compared to Herodotus's *Histories* or Thucydides's *Peloponnesian War*.

Works of philosophy also sometimes have a narrative structure. For instance, the *Lun yu* is a book about Confucius but does so through a documentation of the conversations he had with his pupils.

The novel arises in China from the Ming dynasty onwards. Famous early examples include the *Xiyou ji* (or *Journey to the West*) from 1592. There is also the well-known *Jin ping mei* (*Plum in the Golden Vase*) from 1617, a 100-chapter novel of anonymous authorship, focusing on the daily life of an urban family. These paved the way for other texts, such as Cao Xueqin's *Shitou Ji* or *Honglou meng*, which is "widely acknowledged as the greatest Chinese novel of all time" from the eighteenth century.

Further reading: Yang, Ye, 'Ancient Narratives of China', in *The Encyclopedia of the Novel*, ed. by Peter Melville Logan, Olakunle George, Susan Hegeman, and Efraín Kristal (Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell, 2011), pp. 18–28